

Round And Round

The days and weeks that followed the rookie event were a wildly disorientating rush of tournament-related activity. Think I'm kidding? Just try to follow along.

The competition is broken down into eight weight classes, with thirty-two fighters competing in each. At the start, each weight class gets its own day. So day one features the bantamweights, with all sixteen first-round fights completed. Day two brings the featherweights, then the lightweights on day three and so it goes - until we hit days six and seven. With eight weight classes and only seven days in a week, something's gotta give. The solution? The heavyweight group is split in two, with half going on day six along with the light heavyweights and the other half going on day seven with the super heavies. That makes for twenty-four fights on each of those days, but it also gets the first round over in a single week. Once that's done, they start combining the weight classes. So day nine features the second round for both the bantamweight and featherweight groups. Eight fights each, keeping the daily total at sixteen. Off days are sprinkled in to ensure that every fighter gets a minimum of a week between fights. By the end of the second week, all weight classes will complete their second round. A similar schedule continues to get the third round done in the following week, then the classes get even more jammed together to reduce the semi-final round to a weekend extravaganza in week four. One last week of rest and recuperation, and then the final round is done on Saturday night of week five, with all eight titles being decided.

Confused? Us, too. We have tables and schedules and calendars to help keep things straight, but none of that does justice to the insanity. Off days are scattered in all over the place to keep the spacing right. In fact, there are more off days than active days toward the end. Enough to make it seem like we're all on a nice Australian vacation... which couldn't be further from the truth. With so little time between fights, the only things on the menu were healing, therapy and game-planning. In fact, even the marketing-driven league execs recognized the ridiculous burden they were putting on the fighters. Their solution? For the first four rounds of the tournament, fights would consist of three, three-minute rounds instead of the usual five-minute frames. Not much of a concession, but at least it was something.

No matter how you slice it, these tournaments are chaos. With so many fighters involved, nothing works the way it normally does. Training partners can't be there for each other because both are fighting on the same day. Danni and Steph are right in the thick of it, so the leadership structure doesn't really hold. People are running everywhere and everyone is pressed into service. Here more than any other time, we need out senior fighters to step up - both in and out of the cage. And I'm proud to say that the women of RSI always - ALWAYS - deliver.

Round one was a thing of beauty for Rampage, with twenty-two of twenty-four fighters moving on, including all of our top contenders. The two losses were disappointing, though. Given the way they've been climbing through their respective divisions, I'd certainly hoped for more from both Anna Kendrick and Marzia Prince. But divisional success didn't always translate when it came to the league-wide rankings, and their poor seeds meant the deck was stacked against them from the outset. Meanwhile, we pulled off a couple of stunning upsets of our own, with twentieth seed Cobie Smulders taking out thirteen seed Kristanna Loken at welterweight and twenty-two seed Krystal Forscutt making short work of eleven seed Olivia Wilde at light heavyweight. All in all, the round was as close to perfect as it gets.

Round two wasn't quite as kind, as seven of our remaining fighters bowed out. Krystal quickly ran out of answers when faced with the far more experienced Brooklyn Decker. Cobie was steamrolled by twenty-ninth ranked Sophie Monk - who had already beaten three-seed Gabriela Cilmi and now looked like she was warming up for the tournament run of a lifetime. Lightweight competitor Roselyn Sanchez gave it everything she had, but came up short against three-seed Ali Larter. But the real pain started at middleweight, where Leesh lost to the hated Karen Gillan and Jen Stano - who had not long ago pulled off the unheard of accomplishment of beating league-leader Doutzen Kroes twice in a row - continued her return to reality when she fell to the similarly ranked Josie Maran.

And then it got worse, as a pair of RSI's title hopefuls were eliminated.

How did it happen? Well, sometimes - no matter how good you are - it's just not your night. That's certainly what happened to fourth-seeded Alyson Michalka in the light heavyweight group. Aly fought well and she fought hard... maintaining control throughout most of the fight. But opponent Erika Christensen just would not go away, and late in the third she scored with a perfect counter that caught Aly right on the button. Just like that, down she went.

Meanwhile at bantamweight, it was one of those situations where we couldn't win for losing. I mean, when your sixteenth-seeded fighter rises up to beat her second-seeded opponent... that's cause to throw a party, right? Sure... except when that two seed also happens to be your fighter. Such was the case when Jennifer Morrison came out of nowhere to dominate teammate and title-hopeful Julianne Hough. To be quite honest, I was at a loss to explain it. Familiarity was certainly a factor, but Jen was so good... it felt like it had to be more.

Jules sure seemed to think so.

"I honestly don't know what the hell happened," the long-legged blonde said afterward. "I know Jen pretty well, and as far as I could tell, that wasn't Jen."

And what did the victor have to say?

"I'm just as shocked as Jules."

Great. Who doesn't love a good mystery?

While losing Jules and Aly took a bite out of our title hopes, we did a little biting ourselves. First, the always dangerous Ashley Tisdale knocked three seed Kristin Kreuk out of contention in the bantamweight bracket. Tiz had to dig deep to hang with the talented brunette, but that's just the kind of thing she's known for. Grinding it out and giving her opponent hell the whole way. She did it well enough to keep Kreuk from getting any kind of traction, and long enough to earn herself the decision victory.

Then came a true shocker when twelve seed Stana Katic erased number five, Lindsay Ellingson. Make no mistake... Stana is a quality fighter. But the middleweight group is rich with talent, and Ellingson is among the cream of the crop. Both Britney and Leesh have suffered a number of setbacks against her, so seeing

Stana snatch the win - and quite easily, might I add - was simply stunning. The kind of thing that had me wondering just how far she could go.

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With upsets quickly becoming the story of the tournament, it was fair to say that RSI was holding its own. We'd suffered some casualties, but far fewer than many of the other stables. And most of our best hopes were still on the board. Here's a quick look at where we stood after the first two rounds...

Bantamweight: Losing Jules left us with only Tiz and Jen Morrison as long shots to make the final.

Featherweight: Tiffany was proving worthy of her top seed, with quick victories in her first two fights. Fourth-seeded Emma was locked in - with neither of her early bouts going past the forty-five second mark.

Lightweight: Top-seeded Emily was our only remaining competitor, but she had cruised through her first two fights with ease.

Welterweight: The good news was that both Danni and Amanda made short work of their early opposition. The bad news was that the journey was about to end for one of them, as they were due to face each other in round three.

Middleweight: Stana's amazing run was about to face its toughest test, as she was up against Britney in the next round. Meanwhile, an easy and expected victory for Jennifer Lawrence in round one was followed by an easier and mostly unexpected win over Hilary Swank in round two. A couple of big upsets had shaken up the bottom of that bracket, and - with Karen Gillan as the only top-ten seed still alive in that half - it was starting to look like it was going to be a wild scramble to see which double-digit seed made the final.

Light Heavyweight: Second-seeded Daniela Hantuchova was the only fighter we had left and a lot of high seeds were still hanging around. The path to the championship was not going to be easy, but a little competition never scared Daniela.

Heavyweight: Two seed Catherine Bell had come through the first two rounds with barely a scratch, while sixteen seed Dianna Dahlgren had put together a pair of impressive performances to keep herself in the mix. It looked like her balloon was about to pop though, as defending champion Samantha Hoopes now stood squarely in her path.

Super Heavyweight: Top-seeded Torrie Wilson and fifth-seeded Steph were both looking good. Unfortunately, they were also on a collision course with each other if they both made it out of round three.

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Speaking of the third round, it was... something. Exciting? Yes. Surprising? More than a little. Here's the rundown...

Bantamweight: Tiz's earlier upset of Kreuk had taken everything she had, and a week just wasn't enough time to get her back in top form. She gave it her all against Ksenia Solo, but she just didn't have enough left in the tank and Solo owned the third round to take the decision. I hate to admit it, but I expected the same from Jen. Her win over Jules was no easy task, and I wondered what she'd have left for seventh-seeded Ayumi Hamasaki. The answer was that she had more than enough... because she knocked Hamasaki out cold twenty seven seconds into the fight. First Jules, now Ayumi and she had the sixth-seeded Solo waiting for her in the semi-final. I didn't know what to expect because Morrison had already far exceeded anything I could have anticipated. At this point, I was just standing on the sidelines and watching in awe like everybody else.

Featherweight: Both Tiff and Emma looked like the champions they were in their third round matches. Neither had an easy time of it, but both maintained control throughout and methodically marched their way to victory. Those words don't come close to painting the proper picture, but I don't know what else to say. Both were up against stiff competition - number eight Penelope Cruz for Tiff, while Ms. Watson faced-off with fifth-seeded Portia de Rossi. Both knew they would have to put the work in to win, and both came ready. Tough defense, unwavering confidence and timely, accurate attacks. They were sensational. So good that I would have given both a great shot to make the final. Unfortunately, that wasn't possible... because they were going to have to face each other in the semi-final. As soon as that reality became clear, all I wanted to do was put a bag over my head and have somebody tell me when it was over. I had seen the two of them tear into each other a year ago. I had no desire to see it again.

Lightweight: Emily faced her first real test against eight seed Jordana Brewster. The exam took just over two minutes, and she passed with a grade of KO1. She mowed Brewster down like overgrown fescue and dropped her like a rock with that signature high kick. I was insane to ever get in a cage with that woman. Fucking insane.

Welterweight: Maybe part of the reason I was so upset about the upcoming Mulheron-Watson semi-final was that my soul was crushed by what I had to witness when Danni faced off against Amanda in round three. Not that there was anything necessarily wrong with what happened. It's just that... all the work and training... the effort put in by not only Danni but the whole stable... the results of all that showed up with crystalline clarity in this fight. The ninth-ranked Amanda was her first significant challenge of the tournament... and she never really looked like any kind of challenge at all. From the minute the bell rang, Danni was just... on it. And Mandy seemed to sense it right away. She came out hard, pressuring Danni from every angle. Looking to get at her before she settled in. But there wasn't any way. Danni was settled and calm right from the outset. Whatever Mandy tried, she had an answer for. Her defense was impenetrable. Before long, she started to find lanes to counter through. Mandy kept pressing, clearly thinking that she needed a breakthrough now because there wasn't likely to be a later. By the end of the round, she was almost completely worn out... both from her own exertions and from the way Danni had picked her apart as the round wore on. The break helped little. As she came out for the second, it seemed clear the blonde fighter had already taken her shot and given all she had to give. It was not a poor decision. It's a known fact that Danni gets better the longer a fight goes, and Mandy was one of the few people who knew just how much Ms. Harris had improved over these past months. So going for broke early was probably her best bet. It just didn't pay off. She was more cautious in the second - mostly because she was incapable of keeping up the pace she'd set in the first. This played directly into Danni's hands. She was fresher and unhurt. Her hands were as fast as ever and her accuracy was almost infallible. She was in no

particular hurry. She was already winning, and it was clear the fight was turning even further in her favor. So she stayed at distance and picked her shots. Mandy tried for a while to do things Danni's way. She relied on her defense to slow the action down and give her time to recover. But she was dulled by pain and fatigue. Incapable of controlling Danni in any way. By mid-round, she had gone back on the offensive. Switching to the old *go down swinging* approach. This only made Danni's life easier, and a fight that had been leaning her way now tumbled completely in her direction. But Amanda... well, like most fighters, she didn't know the meaning of the word quit. If she was standing she was fighting... and the one thing Danni couldn't seem to do was knock her down. Seyfried survived the round and - much to Danni's dismay - she answered the bell for the third. The cycle continued. Punches tore skin and drew blood. Things turned ugly, and no one was more upset about it than Danni. She kept backing off. Trying to let the seconds tick by. But Amanda kept coming because that was her job. She lasted the round, and forced the fight to the cards. The decision was obvious and unanimous.

A tearful Danni was in no mood to celebrate afterward.

"I love Mandy, and what I love most about her is her heart," she said, "but god-damn that was hard. Fighting your friends is something we all have to deal with. You try to tell yourself it's just another opponent and you go out there and do your job. But that third round... that was one of the hardest things I've ever done. I'm just glad she's okay."

For her part, Amanda admitted she probably shouldn't have dragged her friend through that, but it's not in her makeup to quit. And when it comes to how she developed that unbending nature, she knew exactly where the blame needed to go.

"I follow the example set by stable leader," said Seyfried - smiling despite her heavily-bandaged face, "and giving up is not the way she taught me to fight."

Maybe it came a little too late, but you have to admire the way Amanda waded through Danni's defenses with that last shot.

Middleweight: Oh, look! More intra-stable fun! But the matchup between Britney and Stana was nothing like the Danni/Amanda debacle. The improvement Stana has shown since joining RSI has been remarkable, and her win over Ellingson has me dreaming of things to come. But she and Britney know each other, so Ms. Katic had no surprises in store for her teammate. She gave it a go and managed to hang in for the entire three rounds, but Brit earned the win by simply being better.

Meanwhile, J-Law put a stop to Nathalie Kelley's string of upsets in the bottom half of the bracket, while Mischa Barton took out Gillan. So, a double-digit semi-finalist was now a guarantee, and I was liking Jen's chances.

Light Heavyweight: Daniela kept right on doing her thing with a solid victory over former champion Caprice Bourret, but a stiff challenge was waiting for her in semi-final in the form of reigning ESL champion Brooklyn Decker. The fun just never stops in that weight class.

Heavyweight: So, this was it. The end of the road for Dianna Dahlgren. Sure, she'd been fantastic, so far. A sixteen seed reaching the quarterfinals? That's definitely something to celebrate. But now it was time for Samantha Hoopes.

That's Samantha Hoopes... phenom of the *Dragon's Den* stable and protégé of longtime FAC champion Caroline Wozniacki.

Samantha Hoopes... winner of this same tournament last year - a run in which she took some time out of her busy schedule to slap our very own Catherine Bell around for about four minutes before advancing to secure her crown.

Samantha Hoopes... the woman they call *The Hammer*.

So, it had been a nice run, but this was clearly where it would all end for Dianna. She wasn't going to be able to work her magic against Hoopes. No way.

Oh, yes way.

Dianna didn't just win. She owned Hoopes. With nothing to lose, she came out firing at the bell. And for whatever reason, she never missed. Hoopes tried to respond, but she just couldn't find an opening. She couldn't lay a glove on Dahlgren, and she couldn't get out of the way when the return salvos came. It went like that all through the first round, with Dianna continuously chipping away while poor Sam searched in vain for an answer. Pain and frustration were written all over her face by the time the bell sounded. It was more of the same in the second, with Hoopes badly bloodied by the final break. She tried to fight on but she was just too far gone, and Dianna finally put her away with a pair of blistering combinations barely a minute into the closing round.

It was a stunning win for Dahlgren... but maybe it shouldn't have been. After all, she and Sam have similar levels of experience, and Dianna has certainly shown she's got the talent to go places. But it's the quality of Sam's wins that elevates her. Especially the victories she picked up during her run through the last year's tournament. She beat Mac. She beat Lindsey Anne Strutt. I mean, holy hell... she beat top-ranked heavyweight Adriana Lima! Surely a woman who can win like that is more than just a flash in the pan, and I don't think losing to Dianna changes that. On the contrary, I think it shows maybe Dianna has a little flash in her, as well. And she was going to get the chance to prove it immediately because former SCQ champion Traci Bingham was going to be waiting for her in the semi-final.

Of course, while Dianna was shocking the oddsmakers, Catherine Bell was marching through the field in her typical, low-key manner. A victory over Lucy Becker might not garner much attention, but it was a solid win over a talented opponent. Besides, while Catherine might not seek the spotlight, she was about to get it shined directly in her face. Because while young Ms. Dahlgren had turned a lot of heads with her win over the protégé, Cat's semi-final opponent was none other than the teacher... *Dragon's Den* superstar Caroline Wozniacki.

That was a matchup EVERYONE would be watching.

Super Heavyweight: The good news... both Steph and Torrie made short work of their opponents to advance to the semi-final. The bad news... remember that collision course I said they were on? Course completed. Collision imminent.

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And that brings us to the semi-finals... where the wheat would definitively separate from the chaff. Two-hundred and fifty-six fighters had started this tournament. When this round was over, only sixteen would be left standing... and RSI still had a lot of dogs in the hunt. Our record for appearances in the final round of a single tournament was six, and that was an extraordinary occurrence. One I never really expect to repeat. But now - with two all-RSI semi-finals coming up - we certainly had the chance to do something big. In fact, I was just starting to let myself believe we might get four this time. Having a fighter in the mix in half the weight classes? That would be one hell of an accomplishment.

How close did we come? Well, let's get to those semi-final results...

Bantamweight: Another round, another stunning upset. Ksenia Solo certainly gave Jennifer Morrison a run for her money, but - after splitting the first two rounds - Jen sealed the deal with a nearly flawless final frame.

First it was Jules, then Hamasaki, and now Solo. All single digit seeds. All done in by the unheralded Jennifer Morrison. You want me to explain it? I can't. I mean, I knew Jen was improving - after all, that's why we brought her to RSI - but this was totally ridiculous. Now the question was, did she have enough left to deal with top-seeded Keira Knightley? Common sense said no, but we were way past that. Jen was on fire, and I was just glad I wasn't the one that had to deal with her.

Featherweight: To be honest, I really don't want to talk about this one because the battle between Emma and Tiffany was about a thousand times worse than I'd feared. I had gone in worried they would tear each other apart, but no... Emma came out firing on all cylinders. Tiff scratched and clawed and made her earn every inch, but there was just no denying Em. Clearly, all the talk about her being unproven had taken a toll, and she was ready to get that monkey off her back. Like Danni, she was as razor sharp as I'd ever seen her, and anyone who got in her way was going to get cut. I don't think I fully comprehended just how motivated she was, but it was right there for all the world to see in this one.

But Tiff... oh that fucking Tiff! I know I shouldn't be mad. And the truth is, I was over it within about five minutes after the fight ended. But in the moment, I was furious.

What did she do? The same thing she always does. No matter how bad things got, she just kept coming. Showing that legendary toughness she was known for. Trouble is, toughness is a double-edged sword. Yes, it can keep you in a fight long enough to turn the tide. But it can also keep you standing long after the tide has gone out and left you stuck hip deep in the mud. Standing there taking punches long after everyone in the arena knows the fight is over. That's what happened in those monumental beatings she took from Nadine Coyle, and the nightmare repeated itself here against Emma.

Emma was the better fighter. It was clear from the outset, and even Tiff knew it. So the blonde took her shots. Hoping to make something happen. To somehow derail the *Emma Express*. But it was obvious by the end of the first that it wasn't going to be Mulheron's night. When the second round started the same way, the facts were clear. Emma was on a mission, and Tiffany wasn't going to be able to stop her. But once again, fighters never quit. It's just not in their DNA. No matter how bad things get, they keep fighting. Believing there's still a chance, even long after there isn't. So Tiff kept coming, showing just enough activity to keep the ref at bay.

By the end of the second, things had started to turn ugly. Tiff was taking a lot of damage, and the results were showing up all over her face. A cut had opened above her left eye, and it was bleeding like crazy. The eye was also swollen, and I was pretty sure it was effecting her vision. Trish and Marcy - who were both pressed into service because we had two competitors in the cage - actually switched places at the second break. Marcy was the injury expert, so she went to Tiff's corner. Trish went with Emma, where she had precious little to do.

That's not to say that all was well in that corner because Em was understandably emotional. Danni was there as her second, and I could see from the way she was gesturing that the discussion had nothing to do with strategy and everything to do with Tiffany. Danni trying to tell her things weren't that bad. That the damage was cosmetic and Tiff had been through worse. All likely true, but Emma wasn't having it. Tiff was a physical wreck, and Emma wanted it to stop. But sure enough, Mulheron answered the bell for the third and the cycle continued. Emma tried to hang back, but Tiff pushed forward and forced the issue. With every punch she threw, Emma's body language seemed to be asking, *Why won't you just FALL?* But Tiff kept coming, and Em had to keep responding to it. I think the whole of RSI breathed a collective sigh of relief when the final bell sounded.

But then, as the stress bled off, the whole nightmare seemed to recede. Marcy got Tiff cleaned up, and it looked like Danni had been right... the damage hadn't been nearly as bad as it looked. The two warriors hugged and I could see Emma yelling at her lover for torturing her that way, but her smile was clearly visible through the tears. They joined the ref at the center, where Emma was officially announced as the winner. Not that there was ever any doubt.

Marcy took Tiff back for some further cleanup, then the two featherweights tackled the post-fight press conference together. Emma was quickly reminded of the unceremonious thumping Tiff had given her in the final of this same event last year. Did the chance at revenge help her get over any concerns she had about going to war with her lover again?

"Not really," she admitted. "I mean, we knew when we started this relationship this was going to happen, sometimes. We've talked about it. We talk about it all the time, actually. But it's not easy, and it never will be."

Tiffany's response to the question was right in step with Emma's.

"What choice do we have?" she said. "We both fight to be the best, and one of the things that makes us who we are is the way we push each other. I would never give that up, but it means we're constantly pushing

ourselves toward moments like this. So, we go out there and give each other everything we have. That's the deal."

Any sore feelings over the lopsided loss Emma handed her?

"Well, let's see..." the Scottish actress began. "My legs are killing me. My head hurts. Got some sore ribs. Maybe a bruised ego. But, otherwise, no. Mostly, I'm just proud of her. Proud of the way she fought. Proud of the way she went for it, even though I know it hurt her a little."

She paused and gave a mirthful smile, then added, "It definitely hurt me worse, though."

"It's called defense, sweetie," Emma teased. "You gotta put your gloves up. When we get back to the gym, I'll show you how it's done."

Tiffany blew out a long sigh and mumbled, "It's gonna be a long flight home."

I can't lie. I felt bad for her. First she has to take the loss, then she has to put up with Emma's mouth?

Of course, there was a good chance she'd done the same to Emma last year. So maybe what comes around, goes around.

With the gut-wrenching battle behind her, I wondered just how hard it would be for Emma to zone back in on her championship goal. But any concerns I had on that front vanished when we found out who her opponent would be.

After the press conference, Danni, Tiffany, Emma and I were together in the locker room when Steph walked in. She didn't even have to speak. The look on her face said it all.

"It's Coyle," Tiffany guessed.

Steph nodded.

Coyle. As in, Nadine Coyle. The woman who had twice beaten Tiffany into a humiliated, bloody wreck.

Emma's response?

"Bring her on."

She sounded pretty damn focused to me.

Lightweight: I know I'm supposed to say something incredible here. To find some way to put into words the weapon that Emily VanCamp has become. I've taken a few shots at it in the past. I've been especially glowing in appraising her unbelievable brawls with Irina Sheik. Using words such as *tough*, *disciplined*, *resourceful* and *lethal*. But, look... I've been doing it for years now, and that's it... I'm done. The thesaurus is all used up. I simply can't do it anymore.

I mean, this is the semi-finals. Winning is supposed to be hard, but Em tore through opponent Sarah Chalke like a chainsaw through tissue paper. Every kick, every punch... everything she threw seemed to find it's mark. Poor Sarah never stood a chance. Which meant the only thing standing between Emily and the belt was Ali Larter. The one thing I'll say, Ali is known for having many of the same qualities Em has. Despite the smile and the friendly demeanor, she somehow radiates strength and toughness. It's unnerving, to be honest. So if anyone was going to stand up to Emily, Ali was a good bet.

Anyway... three weight classes down, three RSI finalists set. We were on a roll. Next up, the Welterweights. Which meant Danni.

Oh, that Danni...